

Derek Thomas

AI SOLUTIONS ARCHITECT · ML SUCCESS ENGINEER

Abu Dhabi, UAE

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Profile Summary

AI Solutions Architect with 10+ years driving production AI adoption. Expert in Generative AI, LLM Deployment & Inference, Technical Communication, and Applied Engineering. I excel in roles that blend research, engineering, and customer enablement to deliver measurable business outcomes.

Experience

Hugging Face (World-leading Open-source AI Unicorn)

[Abu Dhabi, UAE](#)

MACHINE LEARNING SUCCESS ENGINEER

Dec. 2022 – Present

- Drove HF's largest-ever quarter (Q1 2024): single-handedly supported Account Executives to achieve 120% of team goal
- Guided Fortune 500 to startup teams on Agentic Workflows, LLM fine-tuning, RAG, synthetic data generation, and model evaluation for Finance & Healthcare
- Deep expertise in inference optimization: quantization, compact models, multi-LoRA serving, and large-scale profiling; published on Arabic RAG, Speech-to-Speech, and Multi-LoRA
- High-impact speaker at GITEX Dubai, Seoul, and Singapore; grew ML Success team by 300%; pioneered HUGS and SafeCoder

DataRobot (AutoML Platform)

[Abu Dhabi, UAE](#)

CUSTOMER FACING DATA SCIENTIST

Nov. 2021 – Sep. 2022

- First Data Scientist in the MENA region; conducted DataRobot's largest-ever Hugging Face partner webinar
- Delivered 20+ AI use cases across 10 clients: banking propensity models achieved 5x–13x conversion lift; manufacturing drove \$1.6M/yr savings and ~200K ton CO₂ reduction
- Pioneered Transformer integration with AutoML & MLOps monitoring; led DataRobot's first NLP client enablement session

UAE Government Contractor

[Abu Dhabi, UAE](#)

LEAD DATA SCIENTIST / LEAD DATA ENGINEER

Feb. 2021 – Sep. 2021

- Built hybrid cloud Big Data platform processing 6M documents/day as team lead
- Replaced NLP/Geoparsing vendors with Transformer models: saved \$1.9M, improved sentiment recall 20% and NER accuracy 23%

G42 (AI Startup → Unicorn)

[Abu Dhabi, UAE](#)

SENIOR DATA SCIENTIST

Apr. 2019 – Feb. 2021

- Arabic ↔ English MT competitive with Google (± 3 BLEU); led Data Engineering responsible for 78% of BLEU improvement; Apache Airflow pipeline for 24B sentences
- Improved SotA Entity Linking with BERT for 40K articles/day knowledge graph; adaptive PyTorch binarization filter cut OCR character error rate 50%

Saal.ai (AI Startup)

[Abu Dhabi, UAE](#)

DATA SCIENTIST

Mar. 2018 – Apr. 2019

- Built NLP REST microservices: Stance Detection (BERT) and Graph Attention Networks for Text Classification; 7-day oil price forecasting

Rockwell Collins (Government Avionics)

[Cedar Rapids, Iowa, USA](#)

DATA ANALYST; SYSTEMS ENGINEER; FPGA ENGINEER

Jan. 2014 – Dec. 2017

- Developed a real-time data model yielding over \$15,000 in savings its first week of deployment

Publications

- 2020 **CIKM**, Relation Extraction with Self-determined Graph Convolutional Networks
- 2020 **ACL**, Autoencoding Keyword Correlation Graph for Document Clustering
- 2020 **SIGIR**, Attending to Inter-sentential Features in Neural Text Classification

Education

University of Louisville

[Louisville, KY, USA](#)

MENG ELECTRICAL & COMPUTER ENGINEERING — *Magna Cum Laude + Honours*, GPA **4.0**

Dec. 2011 – Dec. 2012

University of Louisville

[Louisville, KY, USA](#)

BSC ELECTRICAL & COMPUTER ENGINEERING, MATHEMATICS MINOR — GPA **3.6**

Aug. 2007 – Dec. 2011